Patna to Bangalore



SHUTTERSTOCK

This was a rather complicated but lovely rail journey I did, where we had to change at Mughal Sarai Junction, Varanasi, Itarsi, and on to Bangalore. In Mughal Sarai, we had a lovely conversation with an official. We asked him where the train to Varanasi (which is just a short distance away) was, but he regrettably said it was indefinitely delayed. So I said to the chap: "You mean it's lost?" and he said: "Yes, you could say it's lost!" So I got a bit excited and angry and replied: "I've come all the way from Patna to catch this train to Varanasi and I'm stuck, and I'm going there for a wedding." And he said: "What can I do?" So, after a bit of an argument, he said to me: "What are we arguing about? There's another train coming in about half an hour and it's going to Varanasi and you'll get there in time." So we did get there in time. That was a very good journey.

Ratlam to Indore

Another wonderful journey, which, I think, is unfortunately being broad gauged—Ratlam to Indore. I've been down one of the most beautiful bits of the railway line, a wonderful ghat line, which ran so steeply. Back then, if you were going up the line, you had to have two engines and you looked down on this gorgeous valley below. This was part of a wonderful railway which ran from Ajmer to Kacheguda near Secunderabad/Hyderabad. When I caught it from Ratlam to the bottom of the ghat line to Indore, it was crowded with milkmen going home with their huge milk cans hanging on the side. The train would stop at some stations for rather a long time, because the milkmen got out to clean their milk churns, and got the driver to let off steam while they did so.



SHUTTERSTOCK

Guwahati to Itanagar

There's a lovely railway journey on the new line going from Guwahati in Assam to Naharlagun near Itanagar. Itanagar itself is rather an unprepossessing capital city, but I think it's the railway journey itself, and the short climb in the last stages with its views of the Eastern Himalayas that are very rewarding.

The Fairy Queen

I have travelled from Delhi to Alwar on the Fairy Queen and stayed the night at Sariska game park. I was travelling with a friend of mine who was a great railway man in Britain. Travelling is wonderful on this historic train which takes you to Alwar, which is full of interesting stories. We travelled with the driver, and at one point, he was going so fast that the guard had to tell him to slow down. I'm a founding member of the Indian Steam Railway Society and we have also rescued steam engines that are now installed in the Rewari Railway Heritage Museum. It's part of the last servicing steam loco shed in which is also housed the Fairy Queen, which is the world's oldest still-functional 1855-built steam locomotive tourist train.



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